

On July 17, 2026, DHS [published](#) a final rule establishing a fixed time period of admission and an extension of stay procedure for F nonimmigrant academic students, J exchange visitors and representatives of foreign information media.

STEM OPT HUB

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STEM OPT EXTENSION OVERVIEW

Last updated: April 28, 2025

The STEM OPT extension is a 24-month period of temporary training that directly relates to an F-1 student's [program of study](#) in an approved STEM field. On May 10, 2016, this extension effectively replaced the previous 17-month STEM OPT extension.

Eligible F-1 students with STEM degrees who finish their program of study and participate in an initial period of regular [post-completion OPT](#) (often for 12 months) have the option to apply for a STEM OPT extension. Students may not apply for STEM OPT extensions during the 60-day grace period following an initial period of regular post-completion OPT.

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Cap-Gap Extension

Students with a timely filed [H-1B](#) petition and a request for a [change of status](#) may apply to receive a "Cap-Gap" extension of their F-1 status and, if applicable, their post-completion OPT employment authorization.

The Cap-Gap extension allows such students to automatically extend the duration of their F-1 status and any current employment authorization until the April 1 the following year.

Entrepreneurship and Employer-Employee Relationships

F-1 students cannot qualify for STEM OPT extensions unless they will be bona fide employees of the employer signing the Form I-983 because F-1 students may not provide employer attestations on their own behalf. However, STEM OPT applicants can participate in a start-up or small business so long as all regulatory requirements are met, including that the employer adheres to the training plan requirements, remains in good standing with E-Verify, will provide compensation to the STEM OPT student commensurate to that provided to similarly situated U.S. workers, and has the resources to comply with the proposed training plan. The employer that signs the Training Plan must be the same entity

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